

The Second *Ask*

The first no is easy. The second ask is where most boundaries fall apart. Here is what to say when they push.

Someone pushes back, adds guilt, or says "just this once." Your instinct is to explain more. Don't. A longer explanation invites negotiation. Repeat yourself calmly, once, and stop talking.

Three rules for the second ask

- **Say the same thing again.** Do not add new reasons. New reasons are new things to argue with.
- **Keep it short.** One sentence is enough.
- **Let the pause sit.** You do not have to fill the silence.

Word-for-word replies

WHEN THEY ASK AGAIN

"I hear you, and my answer is still no. I want to be respectful of your time by being clear now."

WHEN THEY ADD GUILT

"I understand. My answer is still no."

WHEN THEY SAY IT'S URGENT

"I can take this on if we move the deadline on the other project. Which one matters more?"

WHEN THEY SAY "JUST THIS ONCE"

"That doesn't work for me. I hope you understand."

WHEN YOU WANT TO OFFER SOMETHING SMALLER

"I can't take on the whole project, but I could offer a quick call to point you in the right direction."

Boundaries fail in the moment because you are deciding under pressure

Decide now. Pick the person who pushes hardest, and write your reply before the next ask.

The person who usually asks twice:

What they usually say the second time:

My one-sentence reply:

What I will do instead of explaining:

Hold it every time for two weeks. A boundary you keep only sometimes teaches people to ask twice. Most people adjust faster than you expect.



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